COUNTRY REPORTS: DJIBOUTI

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Status report

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Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Djibouti's 2026 budget law orders digital work — the customs single window, the Fichier Unique update and a budget data-exchange platform — but its own tables stop at title-level totals, naming no ICT ministry line, no ANSIE allocation and no e-government envelope.

The umbrella above those mandates changed in mid-2026. The Council of Ministers approved the decree adopting the third National Development Plan, PND-ADEEG 2025-2030, on 30 June 2026, and the World Bank's eighth implementation report records decisions to begin updating the flagship Smart Nation Strategy to align it with the new plan and the new cybersecurity agency, and to speed up the Digital Code's telecommunications and cybersecurity books. The government's own October 2025 digital-maturity diagnostic listed among the main challenges still ahead a national digital strategy and sectoral roadmaps, data-management and cybersecurity policies, and infrastructure modernisation and cloud adoption. Opening the political year on 1 September 2026, the President named the digitalisation of procedures, paperless public services and interoperability between administrations as the means of modernising the state.

The artificial-intelligence strategy has gone furthest. Its main lines, for 2026 to 2030, were presented on 3 September 2026 at the country's first national forum on artificial intelligence, and it is led by the ministry responsible for education, innovation and digital development with UNESCO and UN-ESCWA support; no adopted text is published. The Universal Service Fund has a draft instrument and no decree: a feedback meeting on 20 April 2026 considered the final report defining its regulatory and operational framework, which produced a draft decree, an internal bylaw and an operations guide.

Sectoral work is further on in places. A national digital-transformation strategy for technical and vocational education was officially validated at a CFEN workshop on 6 November 2025, while the draft National Land Policy went to a validation workshop in Tadjourah on 6–7 December 2025 and a national carbon-market framework was tabled for validation in August 2026 after an Agence souveraine carbone had already been given a director-general. On the machinery of government, Djibouti launched the PAGEF public governance reform programme on 11 June 2026 with USD 20 million, and it scores 43.1 out of 100 for Overall Governance in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 38th of 54 African states and below the African average of 49.3, improving 3.9 points over 2014-2023 at a pace that has slowed since 2019.

Most of the digital strategy instruments sitting beneath Vision 2035 are at consultation, validation or revision stage rather than in force.

Legislation and regulation

Djibouti gained a second framework digital statute within six months of the first: the Startup Act, Loi n° 179/AN/25/9ème L, was adopted on 12 November 2025, signed on 1 December and published in the Journal Officiel of 15 December 2025, taking effect from promulgation under article 35. It writes a Startup Visa into primary law, a three-year renewable residence-card category for founders and their employees that carries an automatic work permit, and provides for a regulatory sandbox run under the Haut Conseil Supérieur de l'Économie Numérique et de l'Innovation, a body created by the 2022 law founding the delegate ministry for the digital economy and innovation.

The Code du numérique behind it was adopted on 30 June 2025, promulgated by President Ismaïl Omar Guelleh on 6 July and published in the Journal Officiel of 18 September 2025. It runs to eight books and nearly 800 articles, covering personal data protection, electronic communication, cryptology, e-commerce, consumer rights, cybersecurity and cybercrime, and innovative digital services.

What the statute book did not do, as at 2024, was compel interoperability: no binding law required Djiboutian ministries to connect their systems to the national X-Road data exchange platform, and the World Bank put delays in joining it partly down to the missing legal framework. Much of the running is made by decree and by the annual budget instead. Décret n° 2026-105/PRE of 11 June 2026 assigns the Justice ministry, with MDENI, to implement the digitalisation of legal services, and the 2026 finance law imposes ten-year retention of trade transaction records and a cash-declaration threshold of 1,000,000 Djiboutian francs while creating a two-stage administrative appeal against customs decisions and binding twelve-month advance rulings on classification, origin and valuation. Telecommunications sit outside that momentum: Djibouti Telecom holds the national and international telecommunications monopoly, within a framework set by loi 13 of 1998 and loi 80 of 2004 (January 2026).

Older law still shapes what can be digitised at all: rural policing falls to the National Gendarmerie, which is legally required to keep procès-verbaux and garde-à-vue custody registers by hand.

Data protection

Djibouti's data-protection regime is law: the Digital Code, enacted in June 2025, creates a National Commission for the Protection of Personal Data as an independent supervisory authority with administrative and financial autonomy.

The regime itself is substantial. It runs to 156 articles and requires breach notification to the commission within 72 hours, gives every citizen rights of access, rectification, erasure and portability, makes data protection officers mandatory for public authorities and for large-scale monitoring or sensitive-data processing, and provides for a public register of processing operations, and operates a tiered prior-authorisation regime under which higher-risk processing — biometric and genetic identity data, and processing that uses the national identifier — must be authorised before it begins. Because any processing involving the national identification number needs prior authorisation from the commission, the country's mobile identity programme falls in the highest-scrutiny tier. Book I of the Code, on personal data protection, is carried in the annex published as Journal Officiel special issue n° 04.

Practice has moved as well. Officers of the Police Nationale and the road-safety police wear body-worn cameras permanently on the uniform as an everyday tool (August 2026), under protocols requiring the device to be worn visibly and the subject to be told they are being recorded, with recording triggered either manually or automatically according to the type of intervention or the threat level detected. Elsewhere, co-design workshops in October 2025 for a digital agricultural advisory service wrote their own data-governance framework covering traceability, user feedback and data protection.

Cross-border rules are being written regionally. A July 2025 Horn of Africa Initiative ministerial meeting called on IGAD and the East African Community to pilot a trusted cross-border personal-data-flow mechanism within twelve months.

Regional collaboration

Djibouti holds one of the region's digital institutions on its own soil: the Project Implementation Unit for Phase I of IGAD's Horn of Africa Digital Market Integration project is based in the country, which in May 2026 opened a call for in-country training and mentorship of women- and youth-led MSMEs in gender-sensitive digital trade for delivery between June and December 2026.

On data governance the country is a participant rather than a convener. Its senior policymakers and regulators mapped national data-governance contexts with UNESCO's Data Governance Toolkit, and examined alignment with the African Union Data Policy Framework and the Smart Africa Data Governance Blueprint, at a regional workshop in Nairobi on 9-11 June 2026 that drafted regional data-policy harmonisation roadmaps, alongside Burundi, Ethiopia, Kenya, Somalia, South Sudan, Tanzania and Uganda. Health data is the strand with an actual instrument behind it: IGAD's Regional Health Data Sharing and Protection Policy Framework of June 2022 gives member states guidance on protected, ethical cross-border health-data sharing, and draws on the African Union Convention on Cyber Security and Personal Data Protection and on the ECOWAS and SADC model instruments. The health ministry's secretary-general also represented Djibouti at IGAD's second ministerial meeting on pandemic preparedness in Kampala on 29 August 2025, which inaugurated the regional PREPARE project. Djibouti is also a member state of the Digital Cooperation Organization, whose secretary-general discussed cooperation on artificial intelligence, digital skills and capacity building with the digital economy minister in September 2026.

Djibouti hosted two regional digital-policy convenings on its own territory within three months, an IGAD cyber-resilience workshop at Arta in October 2025 and the African Union's 16th Private Sector Forum in December 2025.

That December 2025 forum ran on the theme of harnessing Africa's digital economy and innovation to accelerate intra-African trade. Beyond the Horn, Djibouti sits on the Dar es Salaam–Nairobi–Addis Ababa–Berbera–Djibouti corridor, one of eleven strategic corridors announced at the February 2022 EU–African Union summit under the Global Gateway package, though that assessment is meant to help EU Delegations, the European Investment Bank and other financiers prioritise where to invest. Regional payments rules covering the country are at terms-of-reference stage, a consultancy to draft them being sought in February 2026, and the cross-border fibre corridors the government leans on are agreements rather than infrastructure in service. Ministerial energy goes largely into courting partners: the communications minister took the digital agenda to the WSIS Forum in Geneva in July 2026, discussing ITU support for digitising public services and, with Smart Africa, alignment of national projects with continental initiatives. Djibouti scores 56.3 out of 100 on Regional Integration in the Ibrahim Index in 2023, 16th of 54 African states and up 10.0 points over 2014-2023.

Standards

Djibouti's standards body began producing standing machinery in 2025: the Agence Djiboutienne des Normes et de la Qualité brought two Comités Techniques de Normalisation into operation during the year, covering agri-food and electrical, electrotechnical and household appliance standards. Its 2026 provisional budget was approved at 134.9 million Djiboutian francs on 13 January 2026, up from 112.1 million in 2025, of which 54.4 million is investment in software, equipment and tooling, IT equipment, laboratory fit-out and vehicles. The agency was founded by Loi n° 100/AN/20/8ème L of 7 January 2021 and organised by decree in May 2022 as a public industrial and commercial

establishment under the Ministry of Commerce and Tourism, charged with contributing to policy on standardisation, metrology, certification, accreditation and quality promotion. It joined ISO and the International Organization of Legal Metrology in 2024 and sits in ISO as a correspondent member.

Radio spectrum is the gap. No national spectrum management plan had been adopted as at November 2025: the regulator ARMD and the ITU held a workshop on 9-10 November 2025 on spectrum strategy, pricing, licensing and sharing, whose recommendations are to found a National Spectrum Management Plan.

For public-sector data the reference document is ANSIE's Cadre d'Interopérabilité, which defines interoperability principles, four layers — legal, organisational, semantic and technical — and a conceptual model for the country's e-government architecture; the framework supports the six axes of the 2020–2022 e-government strategy and the e-governance aims of the "Bonne Gouvernance" pillar of Vision Djibouti 2035. Sector-specific technical norms are set by regulators rather than by the standards agency: the central bank has required by communiqué that from 31 August 2025 cheques conform to SYRAD platform standards, and the composition of the national identification number is fixed by decree. The Code du numérique of 2025 is the framework instrument above all of it, covering personal data protection, electronic communication, cybersecurity and cybercrime, and innovative digital services.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Djibouti's Digital Freedom score in the Ibrahim Index fell 17.0 points over 2014-2023 to 24.6 out of 100, 46th of 54 African states — the third most deteriorated of the country's 96 indicators, and a decline running against its rising infrastructure scores. The wider civic picture is of the same shape: Rights, one of the country's three weakest sub-categories, scores 24.7 out of 100 in 2023, 49th of 54, with Media Freedom at 22.0 and Freedom of Expression and Belief at 44.8 after a 12.5-point rise, and Freedom of Association and Assembly scores 0.0, unchanged across the whole decade. Freedom House scores the country 24 out of 100 and rates government openness and transparency at the lowest available level, and the media regime is still governed by Loi n° 2/AN/92/2ème L of 15 September 1992, never substantially reformed in over three decades (April 2026).

Consultation on digital policy does happen, and the AI strategy is where it has been widest. The workshop of 22 January 2026 drew roughly 80 participants from government, UN agencies, academia, the private sector and civil society, using UNESCO's five-dimension readiness methodology as its diagnostic instrument; the week of bilateral meetings before it surfaced varying levels of awareness of, resistance to and capacity to use AI, alongside strong national commitment. The national development plan was formulated through three weeks of thematic debates in Djibouti-Ville followed by consultations across the five regions in August 2025, each region having to produce a validated contribution report drawing in elected officials, local authorities, civil society and experts.

Where the Digital Code is concerned, the engagement came after the fact: MDENI presented the Code to the France-Djibouti Business Group's General Assembly after it became law (November 2025), with the minister's legal adviser setting out its personal data protection and e-commerce provisions. Transparency instruments are newer still: the PAGEF programme introduces the country's first Budget Citoyen alongside strengthened control and accountability mechanisms.

Public participation in digital policymaking rests on a handful of dated events between April 2022 and February 2026, only some of which put a text to non-state participants before it was settled.

Finance

Financial sustainability

Djibouti cut the 2026 budget of ANSIE, the agency that runs the state's information systems, by 160.6 million Djiboutian francs to 396.1 million, the Council of Ministers citing the creation of the separate cybersecurity authority among its reasons. The agency lives chiefly on a state subsidy plus receipts for its services, and its 108.1 million francs of 2026 investment pays for application firewalls, an archiving system, colocation to back up the data centre and the annual support renewals for the data centre's equipment and the X-Road exchange layer, against 267.9 million of staff costs. Its receipts rest on a tariff decree adopted in Council on 14 November 2023, charging public and parapublic bodies across six service categories, from hosting in the national data centre to network and information-system security.

ANSIE was appropriated 451.7 million francs for 2024 and 556.8 million for 2025, and its 2024 accounts, approved by law in February 2026, show charges of 479.2 million francs against income of 457.1 million. The statistics institute INSTAD was appropriated 485.7 million francs for 2026, all of it income printed as subsidies, up from 456.9 million in 2025. The 2026 estimates print no financing source against their digital lines (FY2026).

The two digital bodies' appropriations read together rose from 897.6 million francs for 2024 to 1,013.7 million for 2025, up 12.9% at the appropriated stage.

Own-source money exists in law and not yet in practice. The 2025 Digital Code obliges telecommunications operators to pay the regulator a share of turnover for the digital development of the territory, and creates a Universal Service Fund fed by a further turnover contribution, both at percentages left to regulation (articles 210, 302 and 308); the fund's draft decree came out of a World Bank-financed mission reviewed on 20 April 2026. The regulator's own 2026 budget of 258.1 million francs draws on spectrum and licence fees and a state subsidy of 139.06 million.

Some of the state's own money goes straight into digitisation: it has put funds into digitising public archives since 2023, and putting 126 years of the Journal officiel online was financed by the President (August 2026). Connectivity for public institutions is still bought externally: the World Bank's Digital Foundations Project was finalising the purchase of internet capacity to connect the remaining public institutions in February 2026.

MoUs and other agreements

Djibouti's largest digital agreement has so far produced nothing on the ground: the memorandum of understanding signed with China's LinkWise Group on 19 July 2026, stated at US$1.35 billion for a 100 MW artificial-intelligence compute centre, up to 500 MW of solar, wind and storage generation, a digital industrial park and international data corridors, is valid for one year, with phase one due for completion within three years. It is to be financed entirely by the investors, with no state equity and no sovereign debt.

The terms the signing minister has set out run to a dedicated artificial-intelligence special economic zone financed by two Shanghai companies, with a policy-stability clause and a tax-exemption period.

Fourteen commitments are on the record, announced between June 2014 and July 2026, and that single unclosed memorandum is worth roughly four times all the finance actually committed to Djibouti's digital sector put together (as at September 2026).

Two instruments have gone further. The Horizon Fiber arrangement between Djibouti Telecom, Ethio telecom and Sudatel began as a memorandum of understanding and became a binding agreement in February 2026, covering a cross-border build with Ethiopia and Sudan. Italy's Fondazione Med-Or has signed a memorandum with the Ministry of Economy and Finance covering critical infrastructure, digital connectivity and strategic dialogue, under which it is building Djiboutian capacity to inspect and protect submarine cables at the landing station.

The rest sit where LinkWise sits. The Smart Wallet memorandum signed with Visa in September 2025 commits the parties to developing a national digital wallet; the European Investment Bank and Sparkle formalised their collaboration on the Blue Raman cable in October 2025; and Djibouti and Romania began exploring digital cooperation in September 2025.

Across the record as a whole the financing arrives as debt rather than grant: seven of the fourteen commitments are concessional loans and three are commercial, against three grants and a single memorandum of understanding (as at September 2026).

New investments

Seven of the fourteen digital commitments on Djibouti's record were active as at September 2026, worth about US$170 million; five had closed, one was approved without disbursing and one stood at pipeline stage.

Djibouti's largest live World Bank operation is the Integrated Slum Upgrading Project, US$50 million in IDA credits and grants, whose December 2025 restructuring sought to extend its additional financing to 31 December 2026, with disbursement then at 68 per cent; the additional financing widened it to two refugee villages and implementation of the National Refugee Law. The Integrated Community Resilience Project, an SDR 23.8 million grant (about US$31 million) approved in March 2025, carries a US$15 million safety-nets component that includes scaling the national Social Registry with an ANSIE interoperability upgrade; the Economic and Financial Governance Project lends US$20 million over 2025 to 2030 for tax administration and financial management systems; and the Digital Foundations Project carries US$10 million to open ICT to competition.

The World Bank holds seven of the fourteen commitments and about US$173 million, roughly half of all committed finance once the unclosed memorandum is set aside; the Islamic Development Bank follows with two submarine-cable loans (as at September 2026).

Before that the money went into cable: US$17 million for the AAE-1 connection over 2015 to 2017 and US$39 million for DARE-1 closed in 2021, both commercial loans from the Islamic Development Bank. The closed Public Administration Modernization Project, SDR 10.4 million approved in 2018, funded an interoperable government platform, a national CERT and a public key infrastructure; the Agence Française de Développement has lent EUR 10 million (about US$11 million) for 2020 to 2027 to digitalise higher education; and the EU and Germany's D4D initiative for digital government and cybersecurity, covering Kenya, Somalia and Djibouti with about EUR 3 million for its GIZ e-government component, closed in 2025.

Two commercial commitments sit outside all of this: Rand Merchant Bank's US$60 million for the data-centre operator Wingu Africa, a facility spanning three countries (June 2025), and a US$10 million private credit facility for the country's digital infrastructure, structured by a Bahraini banking group, its Djibouti subsidiary and TLG Capital (November 2025), with no borrower named.

Connectivity is where the money has gone, three commitments worth about US$66 million, with roughly US$121 million to government systems across registries, public financial management and payments; the much larger data-storage total is almost all unclosed pipeline (as at September 2026).

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Djibouti's regulator granted NetCatOnline SAS an authorisation on 22 March 2026 to build and operate a national wired electronic-communications network, to sell internet access and private data transmission, and to reach Djibouti Telecom's cable-landing stations, in a market where Djibouti Telecom has held the national and international telecommunications monopoly (January 2026).

The international position remains the country's strongest asset. The Prime Minister put the count at fourteen submarine-cable landings on 1 March 2026, with Google's Blue Raman described as coming soon rather than counted in the total. That system, 11,700 km landing in Djibouti, India and Oman, was presented by the European Commission in October 2025 as the physical layer of an EU–Africa–India Digital Corridor and a deliverable under the India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor.

Two cross-border fibre builds are in train. Djibouti Telecom, Ethio telecom and Sudatel signed a binding tripartite agreement on 4 February 2026 for the Horizon Fiber corridor, linking Djibouti's and Sudan's landing stations through Ethiopia and specified at roughly 2,800 km with 144 fibre pairs and about 14 ms latency. On 7 September 2026 the three operators presented the corridor to Google, Meta, Microsoft and Amazon, to other carriers and to equipment makers at a pre-commercialisation meeting in Addis Ababa, seeking partners and customers before deployment and commercial launch. Separately, Djibouti Telecom plans to extend DARE1 along Africa's east coast to South Africa, with a new 3,200–3,500 km link from Mombasa to Mtunzini and a 2028 ready-for-service target.

Both of the cross-border fibre projects Djibouti has joined are running in parallel, and neither has been confirmed complete.

Domestically, internet users reached 65.30% of the population in 2024, from 59.93% in 2020. The country ranks ninth of 54 African states on the Ibrahim Index's internet and computers measure, at 61.2 out of 100 in 2023, and forty-sixth on mobile communications, at 47.3. AMS-IX Djibouti extends the country's existing DjIX exchange. No national spectrum management plan had been adopted as at November 2025, and the universal service fund meant to widen equitable access to electronic communications is still at design stage (April 2026).

Data Storage

Djibouti's largest storage prospect exists on paper only. In July 2026 the government agreed terms for an artificial-intelligence compute zone with a Chinese investor, offering land and guaranteed seawater abstraction rights for cooling, a policy-stability clause, a tax-exemption period, and technical training in place of local employment quotas, all of it inside a memorandum of understanding rather than a signed investment protocol.

What is on the ground is smaller and largely commercial. Wingu Africa's TO7 — a Tier-3 carrier-neutral data centre combined with a submarine cable landing station and an innovation centre, the first integrated facility of its kind in the country — was inaugurated on 25 November 2024. Its Technology Park facility carries 3MW and certified Tier III status, alongside the Djibouti Data Center established in 2013. The operator also provides infrastructure-as-a-service, cloud-as-a-service and satellite teleport capabilities, and raised US$60m from Rand Merchant Bank in June 2025 to expand across Djibouti, Ethiopia and Tanzania. PAIX Data Centres and the sovereign Fonds Souverain de Djibouti announced a joint venture in May 2024 to build a further carrier-neutral facility, JIB1.

On the state side, a World Bank GovTech case study recorded a fully operational government data centre (2024), and a World Bank project that closed on 30 June 2021 was restructured to establish an automated National Payment System. The customs directorate installed a backup site and a new high-availability data centre in 2024. The Secretariat-General of the Government and the UNDP signed a letter of accord on 2 August 2026 to digitise the state's archives, with secure backup of the data hosted at the ANSIE data centre.

Energy

Djibouti's government validated a national energy pact in May 2026 setting a target of 60% rural electricity access by 2030 and universal access by 2035, against a rural access rate of 17.8% and close to 30% of the population unserved. The investment it says this needs is US$1.745bn, of which over US$728m is sought from the private sector (May 2026).

Access and cost are the constraints. Around 65.2% of the population had access to electricity in 2023, residential tariffs are among the highest in Africa, and the contract for the 230kV double-circuit line from Semera substation to Galafi, the Ethiopian side of the second Ethiopia–Djibouti power interconnection, was awarded on 24 November 2025.

Off-grid delivery is at pilot scale. A 165kW off-grid solar plant with 500kWh of battery storage was inaugurated at Adailou in Tadjourah in 2025, bringing reliable electricity to homes, schools, health centres and businesses. Japan funded and the UNDP launched a US$373,333 twelve-month solar pilot on 21 April 2026 at Yoboki in Dikhil and Omar Jaggaa in Arta, pairing electricity with water access and community maintenance. The country scores 37.1 out of 100 on the Ibrahim Index's access to energy measure in 2023, 29th of 54 African states.

Rural access is 42.2 percentage points short of the pact's own 2030 target. The 500 MW of generation pledged to the single artificial-intelligence compute project announced in July 2026 is about three thousand times the capacity of the Adailou plant, and the US$1.35bn behind that project is roughly 77% of the entire investment the pact says universal access requires.

Technical Capacity

A cross-ministry digital-maturity diagnostic presented to the Council of Ministers on 7 October 2025 found the administration fragmented and unevenly equipped, and the bilateral meetings preceding the January 2026 national AI strategy workshop surfaced varying levels of awareness of, resistance to and capacity to use AI.

Institution-building is where the movement is. The new cybersecurity authority was assembled around ANSIE's existing information systems security directorate rather than started from nothing. A dedicated civil-service corps for the statistics institute's staff — statistical engineers, senior administrators and senior technicians — was created by decree published on 12 May 2026, and technical assistance is strengthening INSTAD's own capacity to collect sensitive population data. A digital-skills training programme for civil servants runs with the Digital Cooperation Organization, Oracle University and the national public administration institute.

Further down the system, capacity arrives as donated equipment on borrowed terms. Djibouti's STEM centres run on a split model in which STEMpower supplies the equipment and the initial training while the education ministry and host schools provide premises and ongoing upkeep. IGAD handed over digital equipment to three cross-border health facilities, district health offices and the health ministry's health information system units in December 2024. The standards agency brought two technical standardisation committees into operation during 2025.

Cybersecurity

Loi n° 195/AN/25/9ème L, published in the Journal Officiel on 15 December 2025, creates the Autorité Nationale de Cybersécurité as an autonomous public establishment under the Presidency, built around ANSIE's existing information systems security directorate. The Council of Ministers had approved the bill on 4 November 2025 and appointed the authority's director-general on 18 November 2025; it stood up in December 2025.

The authority follows a strategy and a code rather than preceding them. A National Cybersecurity Strategy for 2024–2030, built on five pillars, was released on 28 November 2024, and the Council of Ministers adopted the decree on it in the week of 29 May 2025. The Code du numérique was published in the Journal Officiel on 18 September 2025, and a World Bank supervision report records a decision to speed up its telecommunications and cybersecurity books (February 2026).

Capability lags the instruments. Djibouti sits in the evolving tier of the ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index (2024). The government's own October 2025 digital-maturity diagnostic still lists putting a cybersecurity policy in place among the challenges ahead. The now-closed Public Administration Modernization Project included creating a national computer emergency response team and a public key infrastructure.

Physical protection of the cables the economy rests on is being built by others. Italy's foreign ministry and Fondazione Med-Or run a project at Djibouti's submarine-cable landing station, under a memorandum of understanding with the finance ministry, to strengthen the Djiboutian authorities' own capability to inspect and protect that infrastructure. Regionally, Djibouti hosted IGAD's cyber-resilience workshop at Arta on 6–8 October 2025, whose purpose was consultation on a regional information sharing and analysis centre still at the stakeholder stage.

DPI

Data Exchange

Djibouti's national data exchange has been built and is little used: integration of government services into the interoperability platform met with delays, fewer than ten platforms using it, partly for want of an enabling legal framework (2024).

The platform is an X-Road installation known as Caravan, completed at the end of 2021 with Estonia's e-Governance Academy and managed by ANSIE, the state information-systems agency. Nothing compelled a ministry to join it: no binding law required connection as at 2024, even though the 2019 identification law had already made the national identification number obligatory for exchanging data between public and parapublic services and a 2022 statute charges the digital economy ministry MDENI with designing, steering and managing e-government.

The current build is the World Bank's Digital Foundations Project, whose pilot phase was connecting 33 ministries, departments and agencies, 11 in Djibouti city and 22 in the regions, the first of them still being connected in February 2026; the generalisation phase beyond it adds roughly 100 more. Five months after the Mobile ID launch the Direction générale de la Population et de la Famille described its own interoperability layer — real-time verification of the identity card for other administrations, banks and social-protection bodies — as still in preparation (July 2026).

Statute keeps running ahead of practice: the 2026 finance law requires the customs and treasury information systems to be interconnected, with daily and monthly reconciliation of fiscal and non-fiscal revenue, and constitutes the Sydonia World clearance system as an electronic single window centralising declarations, certificates of origin, licences, freight manifests, inspection results and sanitary and phytosanitary certificates. Customs is preparing a

further step: an electronic single-window project, set out at a workshop on 1 September 2026, that goes beyond the SYDONIAWORLD system it currently uses, prepared with the commerce ministry, the AfCFTA Secretariat and the Korean agency CUPIA.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The Ministry of the Interior launched a Mobile ID credential on 10 February 2026, and its design keeps the biometrics in one pair of hands: the ministry is to store the biometric data exclusively, other institutions reaching it only through encrypted server-to-server requests, so that partner administrations reach only the authentication services, without direct access to the databases. The government puts the same framing to its financiers, describing the work to a World Bank delegation in March 2026 as sovereignty over citizens' data. At the forum that preceded the launch President Ismaïl Omar Guelleh set the benefits of biometric identity against the risks of identity theft, cloning, hacking, espionage and over-centralisation, and called for continuous public vigilance.

Its priority uses are civil registry services, tax procedures, bank account opening and electronic signature of official documents, with driving licences and selected health information planned for integration, and the digital economy minister named building permits and tax payments among the online services a citizen will reach with it. It complements the national identification number and the modernisation of the civil registers, and digital initiatives across government had remained fragmented for want of a fully formalised national e-government strategy (February 2026).

The statutory base long predates the app. Law No. 39/AN/19 of 21 January 2019 created the Registre National des Personnes Physiques and a national identification number assigned from birth; a 2020 decree fixed the number as a twelve-position code encoding sex, date of birth, a sequence number and a check digit and required it on virtually every official document, from property and hospital records to school, university, utility and commercial ones, telecom subscriber records included. The card is issued for a fee rather than free; foreign nationals residing regularly are eligible for the register.

A national statistics institute survey activity with the World Bank and UNHCR flags that digital identification could inadvertently exclude undocumented residents from healthcare and education. An earlier attempt was abandoned: the e-ID subcomponent of the World Bank's Public Administration Modernization Project was dropped at the first restructuring on 17 March 2022 and never delivered.

Djibouti took seven years to move from founding identity statute to a live biometric credential: eighteen months from the January 2019 law to the July 2020 decree setting the number's technical specification, and a further five and a half years to Mobile ID's launch in February 2026.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Djibouti is a live participant in the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System (2026). Domestically the reach is narrower: AfricaNenda's 2024 review dropped SYRAD from its landscape of live instant payment systems because its instant-payment service was not yet live.

SYRAD, a real-time gross settlement system paired with an automated clearing house, went into service on 15 July 2021 with the Treasury as a participant, and the Banque Centrale de Djibouti owns, oversees and operates it, reporting its volumes and values annually. The statute behind it is Loi n°118/AN/15/7ème L of 16 July 2016, and the central bank has ruled by communiqué that from 31 August 2025 no cheque failing the new SYRAD format, security and encoding standards would be cleared.

Retail use is thin. Fewer than a third of the population hold a bank account (2023), and Access to Banking Services is among Djibouti's ten worst Ibrahim Index indicators, at 10.0 out of 100 in 2023 and 40th of 54 African states. The country's first online payment gateway opened on 10 December 2023, run by the state operator Djibouti Telecom through its D-Money service, which supports person-to-person transfers and merchant payments; electronic payment has since been introduced for vehicle road tax, stamp duty and licensing fees. A national payment gateway for government was part of an e-government architecture still being implemented (2024).

The most-publicised project is still a memorandum: Djibouti signed an MoU with Visa on 16 September 2025 to develop a national Smart Wallet combining payments, government services and digital identity.

Registries

Djibouti's Social Registry held 515,730 people in February 2025 against a target of 600,000, and the World Bank-financed expansion meant to close that gap had not commenced on data to 31 January 2026. A 2020 decree made the register the sole instrument for targeting beneficiaries of social-protection programmes, and its target population is defined as poor Djiboutian households and the refugee population resident on national territory, so refugee inclusion rests on the legal text rather than on programme practice alone.

Civil registration is where digitisation is thinnest: birth, marriage and death registration was processed manually on paper, with no regular process for establishing vital statistics (2017), while Djibouti-Ville has run a computerised civil status system, SIGEC, since 2011 and commissioned an expert diagnostic of it in 2024. The country's Civil Registration score in the Ibrahim Index was 62.5 out of 100 in 2023, 24th of 54 African states, and had not moved at all over the decade.

The land register has the strongest legal footing of the lot: the 2018 land-property law gives the centralised scanned and electronic database of land books legal effect as the operative title and requires every registered private parcel to be mapped and recorded, and obliges the registry to let the public consult it free of charge. Most deed records were computerised or scanned by 2018, sharing a single database and common property identifiers with the cadastral agency, with no electronic database for checking encumbrances and cadastral maps still on paper. A December 2025 World Bank restructuring paper sought a twelve-month extension of the Integrated Slum Upgrading Project's additional financing to 31 December 2026, its activities delayed mostly by resettlement.

The business register, the Registre de Commerce et des Sociétés maintained by ODPIC, is legally mandatory within a month of incorporation and issues registration receipts and certificates. The electoral register for the presidential election of 10 April 2026 was fixed by arrêté at 261,857 voters, against 187,000 registered after the 2016 revision of the roll, which the African Union's observers found had not won the consensus of all parties. For addressing, La Poste de Djibouti adopted what3words as the official national standard in February 2017, assigning a fixed three-word address to every three-metre square of the country.

Terms of reference of February 2024 describe the capital's civil-status system as running since 2011 at three commune centres and five maternity antennas on one central server, and commission a diagnostic of it under a city governance project.

Sectoral management information systems

Health data capture stops short of the community: the national DHIS2 platform does not yet take in community-level data, and there are no community indicators or tools for collecting it (2024). mSupply for pharmaceutical stock was installed across all health facilities by April 2025, and WHO's country office recorded in April 2025 that assessments had shown limitations in the health data system, including challenges in the use of DHIS2, with resources still being sought to revamp it.

In education the ministry made consolidation of the education management information system through the GOSE and SMIS platforms a strategic priority for 2025-2026, aimed at identifying at-risk pupils and tracking them individually. Routine records lagged that architecture: school directors collected data digitally through the OPAD application, but the ministry's statistics office still re-entered it by hand because the systems were incompatible, and the statistical yearbook appeared about seven months late (2019). Djibouti is the first country to have validated 100% of its school locations on Giga Maps (April 2026), after AI identification of school buildings from satellite imagery.

On the revenue side the tax directorate is finishing an Integrated Tax Administration System begun under an earlier World Bank project, with e-filing, e-payment and other modules still to be implemented (December 2024). For the state's own payroll, the 2026 finance law requires the Fichier Unique database of state personnel to be updated to take in contract staff and headcounts awaiting regularisation.

The sectoral management information systems now being built in Djibouti — across education, social protection, health, justice, tax and land — are financed by external donor projects rather than from the domestic budget.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Djibouti counted its public services before digitising them: the digital economy ministry's catalogue, presented to the Council of Ministers on 7 October 2025, inventoried 503 public services — 281 citizen-facing, 187 business-facing and 35 inter-agency — and selected 83 of them for priority digitalisation.

The starting point is low: the UN's E-Government Development Index places Djibouti 174th, in its lowest band with a score below 0.25 (2024), and the Ibrahim Index's Public Administration score reached 47.9 out of 100 in 2023, 31st of 54 African states, with Effective Administration up 12.1 points over the decade to 50.1.

Delivery has lagged the money. The Public Administration Modernization Project disbursed US$14,152,636 against an original commitment of US$15,000,000, closing near its full budget despite having shrunk its delivery target — the Citizen Service Center pilot was cut back at the 2022 restructuring, and a single centre, run with La Poste, opened in Djibouti city in August 2023, giving access to the services of the egouv.dj platform. Its successor on public finance had effectiveness pushed to 9 March 2026 by a third extension and its ratings downgraded to Moderately Satisfactory, reporting tax e-filing at 0% against a 70% target set for December 2029, and a public-financial-management reform programme, PAGEF, was launched on 11 June 2026 with components covering tax administration, public expenditure, financial information systems and e-government. Two further services were being prepared for deployment in May 2024: an e-Cabinet platform for government business and an online building-permit portal, both under the Djibouti Digital Foundations project.

What is running is narrower and mostly transactional. Electronic customs clearance is compulsory under the 2026 annual finance law rather than under a standalone digital-administration statute, on an ASYCUDAWorld installation the World Bank had already written up in 2024 as a worked example of digitising a core revenue and trade-facilitation function. An online company-creation platform opened in January 2026, letting entrepreneurs complete company formation without attending in person; La Poste takes online orders for criminal-record extracts and certificates of non-conviction; a public procurement portal was instituted by decree in February 2023, and the state information-systems agency presented a virtual assistant for it in June 2025; the labour ministry presented Djibouti Emploi, a single employment portal for jobseekers, employers and the administration, on 24 August 2026; and the urban rehabilitation agency ARULoS runs E-Doleances, an online complaint portal routing recovery and technical complaints to named internal divisions. On 2 August 2026 the Secrétariat général du Gouvernement and the UNDP signed a letter of accord to take the state's archives off paper, covering indexing, digitisation, training of a national team and secure backup of the data at the ANSIE data centre.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Damerjog, in the Arta region, had been connected by October 2025 under the Djibouti Fondement du Numérique programme, which brought a school of more than 1,200 pupils, a sub-prefecture office and a polyclinic onto high-speed internet. The pilot phase of the World Bank-financed Djibouti Digital Foundations Project is connecting 33 ministries, departments and agencies, 22 of them in the regions and 11 in the capital (February 2026).

Two-thirds of the agencies connected under that pilot sit outside Djibouti city, so the sub-national reach of the interoperability build is already most of what has been delivered rather than a later phase.

Connection is not yet participation. The capital has run its own computerised civil status management system, SIGEC, since 2011, and the municipality commissioned an international expert diagnostic of it in 2024 with modernisation and data security in view. The World Bank's now-closed Public Administration Modernization Project dropped its e-ID subcomponent and reduced its Citizen Service Center pilot in scope at a 2022 restructuring.

The clearest transfer of a service to an elected sub-national body is not a digital one. Civil-status administration passed from the prefectural administration to the Dikhil Regional Council at a ceremony on 27 April 2026, marked by the opening of a branch office in the sous-préfecture de Mouloud.

Rural digital data capture

Registration reached deeper into rural Dikhil on 27 April 2026, when a civil-status branch office opened in the sous-préfecture de Mouloud. What it extends is a civil registration service that processed births, marriages and deaths manually on paper, with no regular process for establishing vital statistics (2017).

Health data capture stops short of the community. The Ministry of Health's DHIS2 platform does not yet take in community-level data, and there are no community indicators or tools for collecting it (2024). Where fibre has arrived the change is abrupt: fibre from the Djibouti Fondement du Numérique programme, which had deployed more than 200 km, reached Ali-Sabieh regional hospital, replacing an exchange of medical records with specialists at the Peltier hospital that could take up to a whole day with instant sharing (June 2025).

Schools are the one rural network where routine capture is already partly digital: a tablet-based classroom observation tool was made mandatory for inspections in all primary schools, with pedagogical advisors' data sent directly to a central server (July 2024).

Agriculture is being designed for the constraint rather than around it. AfDB-supported co-design workshops in Djibouti City on 6–7 October 2025 under the BREFONS programme produced digital advisory services for the Ali-Sabieh and Tadjourah regions, built as interactive voice response scripts, micro-videos, agro-meteorological bulletin templates and community-radio content in Somali and Afar, for low-connectivity, mixed-literacy rural users.

The governance measures behind all of this move in opposite directions. Rural Market Access fell 6.3 points over 2014-2023 to 9.4 out of 100, 37th of 54 African states and among Djibouti's ten worst-scoring indicators in the Ibrahim Index, even as the Rural Economy score rose 8.7 points to 45.9 (2023). Rural Representation and Participation is the country's fifth most improved indicator, up 22.8 points to 49.5, and Rural Land and Water Access rose 14.4 points to 73.3, eleventh of 54 (2023).

French military specialists rebuilt the national gendarmerie's intranet over three weeks in October 2024 so that headquarters can again message and share files with its brigades. The force's own account lists 13 brigades and a 2004 fingerprint file due for replacement.

Technology

AI

No Djiboutian law addressed artificial intelligence specifically as at August 2026, and the national strategy meant to set the direction had its main lines presented on 3 September 2026 at the country's first national AI forum, covering 2026 to 2030 around six priorities - data and AI governance, cybersecurity, training, research, innovation and inclusion - with tools working in Somali, Afar and Arabic named as the means of limiting a new digital divide.

Drafting ran through 2026 with UN-ESCWA and UNESCO support, public institutions being consulted at a workshop in Djibouti on 22 January 2026. The week of bilateral meetings that preceded it found uneven awareness of AI across institutions, uneven capacity to act on it, and resistance among some of those consulted.

The national diagnostic behind the strategy, run on UNESCO's readiness methodology, placed Djibouti at an emergent stage, with none of its five dimensions — legal, social and cultural, scientific and educational, economic, and technical and infrastructural — rated better than medium (August 2026).

What is actually running is narrow and sits in one sector. The national readiness diagnostic finds AI use emerging in port logistics (August 2026), the Djibouti Ports Community System and Corridor Vision AI among them. An AI weather system reached the country outside the strategy process altogether: China's MAZU-Djibouti 2.0, a monitoring and alerting system supporting port activities, was handed over on 17 July 2026. The compute centre announced with Shanghai investors the same month is a memorandum that opens the way to detailed technical studies, valid for one year.

The domestic base for any of this is small. The Université de Djibouti opened its first master's degree in artificial intelligence and data modelling in September 2025, and Djibouti Telecom certified 35 of its engineers in artificial intelligence on 17 September 2026.

ICT Industry

Djibouti Telecom's monopoly on national and international telecommunications faced a newly authorised entrant on 22 March 2026, when the regulator cleared a private operator to build and run a national wired network, sell internet access and reach the cable landing stations.

On the industry's own side, the process of creating a national federation of digital enterprises was launched in December 2025, Djibouti having been named a founding country of the African federation set up under the Marrakech Declaration.

Government demand is being reorganised around the sector rather than expanded into it. The ministry responsible for ICT began designing a government-to-business one-stop platform for small and medium enterprises in December 2025; company registration is already centralised and legally compulsory. The private-sector and digital lines of the European Union's 2021-2027 country programme run to MSME capacity, women's economic leadership and digital skills.

Abroad, the sector is the pitch: the finance and industry minister presented Djibouti to China Exim Bank in Beijing in June 2026, with a new roadmap for industrial cooperation, as an emerging platform for artificial intelligence and digital innovation.

Innovation ecosystem

Djibouti's Startup Act, in force since its promulgation in December 2025, creates a state "Startup" label granted by ministerial order on the binding opinion of a Collège des Startups, with a national Startup Djibouti portal centralising applications.

The gate is narrow. A company must be under seven years old, built on technological innovation, with more than half its capital held by natural persons or seed investors, and it pays no dividends while it holds the label. What it buys is chiefly at the border: a simplified customs regime for imports used in research and development, prototyping and production. The same law also carries a renewable startup visa, a regulatory sandbox and state-backed investment vehicles including a fund of funds and a crowdfunding regime.

The institutions the law will work through are few. Two hubs carry the sector: CTID, the country's first incubator, established in 2017 and still running entrepreneurship events and training cohorts, and Startup Djibouti, a government-backed accelerator offering incubation, acceleration and grant funding (2024). To those the state added LIMO in July 2026, a platform meant to route startups, developers and entrepreneurs towards support mechanisms, and work on an École 42 coding campus launched in April 2026 with the European Union, Expertise France and Association 42.

Home-grown firms are visible but few and small: one Djiboutian company was running a marketplace and delivery service across merchants, restaurants and pharmacies in June 2026, settling in cash on delivery and selected mobile money. Donor programmes supply much of the rest of the pipeline, among them digital agricultural advisory services designed for Ali-Sabieh and Tadjourah at workshops in October 2025 under an African Development Bank programme. The framing goes back to the Digital Economy and Innovation Roadmap launched in April 2022, which set out digital economic transformation, digital administration, sectors and professions of the future, and citizen participation.

Capacity

Literacy

Djibouti ranks 5th of 54 African states for Human Resources in Education in the Ibrahim Index, scoring 96.1 out of 100 in 2023 after a 12.8-point rise, and its Education Quality score rose 16.7 points over the same window to 50.0, 19th of 54 (2023). Enrolment is where the record breaks: Education Enrolment stands at 29.2, 43rd of 54 (2023), the country's weakest education measure despite a 6.0-point gain, while the overall Education score is up 10.0 points across 2014-2023 to 54.2, 25th of 54. Staffing has improved far faster than the number of children reached.

Digital provision inside schools is new and small. Two STEM centres opened in September 2025, at the Lycée de Djibouti and the Lycée de Hodane, each equipped with computer and electronics laboratories and staffed with dedicated mentors.

Routine school records have been slow to go digital. Primary school directors collected data digitally through the OPAD decision-support application, but the statistics office still re-entered it by hand (2019), and the education ministry was developing a digital education management platform with a unique student identification number to follow learners through their school career (January 2024). Where services are designed for people who read little, the pattern is voice and radio rather than text: agricultural advisory content in Somali and Afar is being built as interactive voice response scripts, micro-videos, agro-meteorological bulletins and community-radio material for low-connectivity, mixed-literacy rural users (October 2025).

Training and skills

The World Bank-supported SKILLS Project had trained around 1,500 people by April 2026, across logistics, construction, energy, hospitality, big data and cybersecurity, and sixteen of its candidates had been placed in employment in Canada by then, with Gulf Cooperation Council placements under discussion. Its courses are market-demand-driven and co-designed with employers, and it is run with the ministries of education and labour rather than MENFOP alone.

E-SKILLS, worth EUR 7m over four years and implemented by Expertise France with Djibouti's digital ministry, was launched on 24 November 2025 and targets over 3,000 young people and women by 2029 through Campus 42 Djibouti and regional Maisons du Numérique; a feasibility study for its Digital Houses across the five inland regions was launched (May 2026). Work on École 42, a coding school, has been launched with the European Union, Expertise France and Association 42 (April 2026).

Short cohorts are most of what has been delivered. 240 young Djiboutians completed MENFOP's D-CLIC training in cybersecurity, mobile development and web development, at a closing ceremony on 21 October 2025; a civil-service digital-skills programme runs with the Digital Cooperation Organization, Oracle University and the administration institute INAP (February 2025); and IGAD, whose implementation unit sits in Djibouti, opened a call in May 2026 for digital-trade training and mentorship for women- and youth-led MSMEs, to run from June to December 2026.

The EFTP digital-transformation strategy, developed from 28 May 2025 with OIF/IFEF support, proposes an action programme built around digital tools in learning, graduate tracking and job placement. School-level provision is exposed on recurrent cost: the STEM centres run on a split model, STEMpower supplying equipment and initial training, MENFOP and the host schools the premises and upkeep. The constraint may not be training: much of the unemployed already hold an upper-secondary or tertiary qualification, in a majority-informal job market (2025).

Three digital-skills instruments — E-SKILLS, IGAD's digital-trade training call and the SKILLS Project — all name women and youth as target populations, and only one has reported any outcome figure against its own target (May 2026). The Francophonie organisation and the education ministry signed an agreement to train 200 young people in development, networks and cybersecurity (2026).

Research institutions

Djibouti's research connectivity is being arranged at corridor level: the memorandum accompanying the EU-Africa-India Digital Corridor pairs Europe's GEANT research network with India's National Knowledge Network and Africa's UbuntuNet Alliance for research and education connectivity (October 2025).

The domestic base is institutional rather than large. The Centre d'Étude et de Recherche de Djibouti is the principal data user of the national space programme HYDROSAT, which flies two 1U CubeSats supervised by MENSUR through the Agence Spatiale Djiboutienne, and ten Djiboutian students were sent to the Centre Spatial Universitaire de Montpellier to train in designing and building space systems. CRIPEN, the educational research and production institution, is attached directly to the education ministry under the 2024 reorganisation law.

University research capacity in digital fields is being built from a low base and with external money: the Université de Djibouti opened its first master's in artificial intelligence and data modelling in September 2025, and the digitalisation and professionalisation of higher education is financed on concessional terms through to 2027. Academics were among the constituencies at the January 2026 consultation on a national AI strategy, and Italy's minister for universities and research visited Djibouti's submarine-cable landing station (August 2026).

Inclusion

Access to services

51.8% of Djibouti's working-age population was outside the labour force altogether in 2025, and 46.2% of 16-24-year-olds were not in employment, education or training. 40.3% of the unemployed already held an upper-secondary or tertiary qualification (2025), which points at a shortage of jobs rather than of schooling. On the first results of the 2025 EDST labour force survey, 77.9% of private-sector jobs are informal, and employment in Djibouti City is concentrated in services at 70.4% (2025), while the economy outside the capital is more mixed, agriculture accounting for 17.1% of employment.

The gate to most services is the identity card. It is legally required proof of identity and a prerequisite for voter registration, passports, government benefits, employment and school enrolment, so people without a valid card, particularly parts of the nomadic population, risk exclusion from them, and issuance is fee-based rather than free, on tariffs set by decree. A survey activity run with the national statistics institute, IOM and UNHCR flags that the country's digital identification systems could inadvertently exclude undocumented residents from healthcare and education. Against that, the Social Registry's own decree names the refugee population resident on national territory in its target group, so refugee inclusion rests on legal text rather than on programme practice alone. Loi n° 151/AN/22 obliges the state to give persons with special needs access to information and communication, ICT systems and electronic services included, and to set minimum national accessibility standards.

Physical reach extends one office at a time: a civil-status branch opened in the sous-préfecture de Mouloud on 27 April 2026, in a rural part of the Dikhil region, while the Universal Service Fund for equitable access to communications remains at design stage (April 2026). Online, the public can order a criminal record extract from La Poste, register a company on a platform launched in January 2026 and file complaints to the housing agency through its E-Doléances portal. On land, the validation workshop for the draft National Land Policy in December 2025 addressed access for women, youth and vulnerable groups.

Digital divides

Djibouti reaches the African top ten on the Ibrahim Index's Internet & Computers measure, at 61.2 out of 100 in 2023 and 9th of 54 states after a 27.4-point rise over the decade; Access to Banking Services, at 10.0 out of 100 in the same year and 40th of 54, is among its ten worst-scoring indicators, having gained 4.8 points over 2014-2023. Connectivity is not the constraint on who participates.

The measures of how evenly the country's institutions reach people have barely moved. Equal Access to Public Services stood at 30.5 out of 100 in 2023, 37th of 54, and Equal Socioeconomic Opportunity at 35.8, 38th, both having shifted less than three points over the decade. Rural Market Access went backwards, falling 6.3 points to 9.4 and 37th of 54 — likewise one of the ten worst — while the broader Rural Economy score rose 8.7 points to 45.9, 38th of 54. Education rose 10.0 points to 54.2 and 25th of 54, but Education Enrolment remains the weakest of its education measures at 29.2, 43rd of 54, and the urban-rural gap in electricity access (2023) sits underneath all of it.

What is being spent is aimed at the geography rather than at the groups. Fibre laid under the Djibouti Fondement du Numérique programme reached Ali-Sabieh regional hospital by June 2025, replacing an exchange of medical records that could take up to a whole day with instant sharing, and a feasibility study for E-SKILLS "Digital Houses" in the five inland regions was launched (May 2026). At the WSIS Forum in Geneva in July 2026 the government presented that broadband build-out, with the regional EARDIP project, as reducing the digital divide and making the country a major connection point for the sub-region, setting out a vision of digital development balancing innovation, security and inclusion.

Data

National statistics

INSTAD ran Djibouti's first nationally representative labour force survey, the EDST, in 2025, a survey type the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators recorded as missing from the previous decade, alongside agricultural and business surveys, as late as 2023. The third general population and housing census collected its data in April and May 2024, and its definitive results report was published through UNFPA Djibouti (2026). INSTAD published a national directory mapping localities and their resident populations on 18 November 2025, and launched regional fieldwork for the seventh Multiple Indicator Cluster Survey at the end of December 2025.

The weakness sits upstream. On the same 2023 indicators Djibouti scores below 20% on data sources — the pillar covering censuses, surveys and administrative data — against 50-69% on data use, data products and data infrastructure; it has held no agricultural and no economic or business census in twenty years, and civil registration was processed manually on paper (2017). Its Capacity of the Statistical System score rose 14.3 points over 2014-2023 and still reached only 35.4 out of 100 in 2023, 40th of 54 African states, and the Ibrahim Index holds no data at all for 16 of its 96 indicators for Djibouti, among them every public-perception measure.

A decree of 12 May 2026 created a statut particulier for INSTAD's cadres, a dedicated civil-service corps of statisticians, and the institute's 2026 forecast budget was approved at 485,686,344 Djiboutian francs. SNDS-3, the third national statistics strategy for 2025-2029, financed by the World Bank, has been validated, and names digitalising collection, database interoperability and disaggregated SDG statistics as its challenges.

Labour-market statistics sit with a line ministry rather than the institute, in the Observatoire de l'Emploi et des Qualifications inside the employment agency ANEFIP, whose founding decree requires an employment and skills database built from administrative sources. INSTAD is working with the World Bank-UNHCR Joint Data Center, IOM and UNHCR to build a boosted displaced-population sample into the EDAM5 household survey.

The system rests on administrative-data streams held by line ministries as well as by the central institute: meteorology under a 2012 decree and employment under a 2015 decree both predate the 2025-2029 strategy by a decade.

Open data

Djibouti has digitised and published online 126 years of the republic's legal record in the Journal officiel (August 2026). The e-JO platform puts laws, decrees, orders and decisions online for consultation at any time, drawing 2,000 to 2,500 consultations a month (March 2026), and President Guelleh spoke at the inaugural ceremony of the African Forum of Official Journals on 15 October 2025.

Little else is open. Across the categories the Open Data Inventory assessed in 2024, no category reaches six out of ten: population and vital statistics score 5.5, and balance of payments, government finance, price statistics and gender statistics five. Five categories score zero — information and communications technology, agriculture, energy, pollution and poverty. On the Ibrahim Index, Djibouti scores 0.0 out of 100 on Disclosure of Public Records in 2023, last of 54 African states and down 12.5 points over the decade, and 8.7 on Accessibility of Public Records, 48th of 54; Accountability and Transparency is its worst of the index's 16 sub-categories at 12.6 out of 100, 51st of 54, and its steepest ten-year decline.

Across the 23 categories the inventory records for Djibouti, mean openness comes to 3.1 out of ten (2024).

Some rights exist on paper: the 2018 land-property law gives the public the right to consult the centralised electronic land register free of charge. Article 38 of the 2026 finance law requires the budget-execution directorate to stand up a prices database and a data-exchange platform with every central-administration department. The central bank is one of the few publishers with a routine of its own, issuing audited annual financial statements as downloadable documents.

Use of satellite data

The China Meteorological Administration handed MAZU-Djibouti 2.0 to Djibouti on 17 July 2026, an AI-driven monitoring and alerting system supporting port activities. The upgrade sharpened forecast resolution from 9km to 3km, with three-day forecasts refreshed every six hours, and added a terminal with integrated meteorological chips, completing a chain from space-based monitoring through modelling to one-click alerts. It builds on MAZU-Urban, commissioned on 18 December 2025, which supports aviation weather services at the international airport and operational safety at ports such as Doraleh, with extreme-weather tracking for heat and heavy rain and implements a FOCAC commitment. The national meteorological agency itself ran four automatic weather stations, all in the south and none compliant with the global basic observing network, and its PUMA satellite workstation was not operational, imagery and model output being taken from the web (March 2025).

Djibouti's own programme is a different kind of asset. HYDROSAT flies two 1U CubeSats supervised by MENSUR through the Agence Spatiale Djiboutienne, and its primary mission is store-and-forward data collection rather than imaging: the payload interrogates ground stations and collects up to 4.2MB of data, received by the national research centre several times a day. The secondary imaging payload resolves at 1km per pixel with files capped at 40KB, too coarse for crop-level or land-parcel observation. DJIBOUTI-1A launched in November 2023 into a 525km sun-synchronous orbit giving two overflights a day and DJIBOUTI-1B on 21 December 2024 into a 550km orbit giving roughly four; either can be commanded from the agency's ground station or from Montpellier, and both carry a two-year nominal mission life against a five-year orbital lifetime.

DJIBOUTI-1A passed that two-year mark around November 2025 and DJIBOUTI-1B reaches it in December 2026. The two postures point opposite ways on ownership: the sovereign asset is a coarse ground-station relay, while the operationally consequential capability — port and airport hazard alerting — runs on Chinese satellites, models and hardware, donated rather than procured.

Earth observation of the land itself is regional. IGAD, headquartered in Djibouti, issued an expression of interest on 5 March 2026 for a consultant to build satellite-based crop-condition monitoring across the member states, using vegetation, soil-moisture, land-surface-temperature and rainfall-anomaly indicators to detect crop stress and feed ICPAC's regional early-warning dashboards. Domestically, a JICA-supported project to modernise the management of geospatial information closed in December 2025, and the country's school estate has been validated from satellite imagery on Giga Maps.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

American engagement with Djibouti's digital layer runs through two firms rather than through Washington. Visa took the retail-payments side: a memorandum for a national Smart Wallet was signed by Visa's regional head of Government Solutions for CEMEA opposite Djibouti's minister Mariam Hamadou Ali, during a three-day visit by a Visa and Tech5 delegation (September 2025).

The infrastructure side is cable. Google announced in July 2021 that it was building the Raman submarine cable system with Sparkle and other partners, a 16-fibre-pair system landing in Djibouti alongside Jordan, Saudi Arabia, Oman and India. That system has since been claimed by others, presented by the European Commission in October 2025 as the physical layer of an EU-Africa-India Digital Corridor rather than as a bilateral American one. Google, Meta, Microsoft and Amazon were among the prospective partners and customers shown the Horizon terrestrial fibre corridor at Addis Ababa on 7 September 2026, with no commitment reported.

China activities

China handed a second artificial-intelligence weather-alerting system, with a monitoring and alerting terminal, to Djibouti in July 2026. The first system was commissioned in December 2025 to support aviation weather at the international airport and operational safety at the ports; a Shanghai delegation trained Djiboutian staff on site before handing it over, and the China Meteorological Administration presents the donation as implementing the consensus reached at the FOCAC Beijing summit of September 2025.

Djibouti has been courting Chinese capital for the compute layer as well. Minister Dawaleh presented the country to China Exim Bank in Beijing in June 2026 as an emerging platform for artificial intelligence and digital innovation, alongside a new roadmap for industrial cooperation with China. A month later a memorandum with Shanghai's LinkWise Group set out an AI compute centre, paired clean generation and a digital industrial park, presented by the signing minister as laying the foundations of national competitiveness for the next thirty years — a dedicated AI special economic zone whose capital, chips and data corridor to Shanghai are foreign, and whose stated success test includes full Djiboutian jurisdiction over data generated on its territory. Minister Helem closed a Geneva mission in July 2026 seeking Chinese backing alongside ITU and Smart Africa support for the country's digital hub ambition, and on 16 September 2026 the communications minister met Huawei's vice-president for North, North-West and Central Africa on cooperation in digital infrastructure and services, calling the firm a leading partner.

The pattern predates the AI file. China's Ministry of Commerce financed the Urban Security Monitoring System, a video surveillance network for Djibouti City and the surrounding region, under an exchange of letters signed in 2017, with China Railway Construction Group taking the construction contract in April 2018 and China training Djiboutian public security agents that May.

EU activities

Italy has opened the most physical strand of European engagement. Fondazione Med-Or, with Italy's foreign ministry, is running a project to strengthen Djiboutian capacity to inspect and protect the submarine cables at the landing station, under a memorandum with the Ministry of Economy and Finance covering critical infrastructure, digital connectivity and strategic dialogue; Italy's universities and research minister visited the station on a mission under the Piano Mattei to open research and training cooperation (August 2026).

The Union's own programme is modest beside the diplomacy around it. The EU has EUR 82 million in support for Djibouti over 2021-2027, financed mainly through NDICI-Global Europe and aligned with Global Gateway, delivered under a Team Europe arrangement that unites Germany and France alongside the European Investment Bank. Its named private-sector and digital line items are MSME capacity and entrepreneurship, women's economic leadership and the promotion of digital skills, with the governance strand extending to digitalisation of public services, including an e-cabinet and an e-permit system.

Skills is where the money has actually gone: an EU-funded E-SKILLS programme implemented by Expertise France with the digital ministry launched on 24 November 2025, targeting young people and women through Campus 42 Djibouti and regional Maisons du Numerique, and Djibouti has launched work on an École 42 coding school with the European Union, Expertise France and Association 42 (April 2026).

On connectivity the framing runs ahead of the finance. The European Commission and partners presented the EU-Africa-India Digital Corridor, centred on the Blue Raman cable, at the Global Gateway Forum in Brussels on 10 October 2025 as a step in the Global Gateway strategy, naming Djibouti a landing country, where the European Investment Bank and the cable's promoter Sparkle also formalised their collaboration. Djibouti sits on one of the eleven strategic corridors announced at the February 2022 EU-African Union summit, running Dar es Salaam-Nairobi-Addis Ababa-Berbera-Djibouti; the Commission's Joint Research Centre, assessing all eleven, found digitalisation the most challenging objective of the set, the exercise being meant to help EU Delegations, the EIB and member states prioritise investment.

Gulf/UAE activities

The one Gulf-originated finance on the record is private: a Bahraini banking group and its Djibouti subsidiary structured a US$10 million private credit facility for the country's digital infrastructure with TLG Capital in November 2025, naming no borrower. No Gulf government has a digital instrument with Djibouti on the record, and engagement otherwise shows up as a labour-market question: Gulf Cooperation Council placements for graduates of Djibouti's SKILLS Project were still under discussion in April 2026, by which point sixteen of the programme's candidates had been placed in employment in Canada.

India activities

Djibouti has begun courting Indian industry directly for its AI ambitions. Working through India's ESC export-promotion council, the government invited Indian AI companies to its National Forum on Artificial Intelligence of 2-3 September 2026, offering visa-support letters and presenting the Forum's official launch of the national AI strategy as a platform for business partnerships, technology collaboration and investment (July 2026), placing India alongside China as a courted partner on artificial intelligence.

India's other route in is the cable. The European Commission presented the EU-Africa-India Digital Corridor, centred on the 11,700 km Blue Raman system landing in Djibouti, India and Oman, as a concrete deliverable under the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor announced at the September 2023 G20 summit in New Delhi, with an accompanying memorandum pairing Europe's GEANT research network with India's National Knowledge Network and Africa's UbuntuNet Alliance for research and education connectivity (October 2025).

Digital sovereignty

Djibouti's 2025 Digital Code writes exit terms into law for one class of data: a host of health data must hold a certificate from the national cybersecurity authority, and its contract must state where the data is held, how portability and reversibility work, and commit the host to return all the data and destroy its copies at the end (articles 758 and 760).

The rest of the Code governs transfers rather than storage: personal data may leave the country only for a jurisdiction the data-protection commission judges adequate, or with its authorisation (articles 99 to 102). No instrument fixing where state data is held or under whose law it is processed was in force as at September 2026. The government told its first national AI forum on 2 September 2026 that it intends to develop national sovereign-cloud and high-performance computing capacity, a goal rather than an instrument.

The core systems on record are run by state bodies. ANSIE's data centre is to hold the secure backup of the digitised state archives, and its 2026 budget pays for colocation to back that data centre up and for annual support contracts on its equipment and on X-Road. The Interior ministry stores the Mobile ID biometric data exclusively, other institutions reaching it only through encrypted server-to-server requests, and the central bank owns and operates the SYRAD payment system.

On AI, the January 2026 consultation on the draft national strategy covered data governance and digital sovereignty, while the one AI system in state service on record, China's MAZU-Djibouti 2.0 port weather-alerting system, was handed over with its own terminal in July 2026. The terms on which the LinkWise compute memorandum and the Visa Smart Wallet memorandum govern data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026. Regionally, Djibouti's policymakers examined alignment with the African Union Data Policy Framework at a UNESCO workshop in Nairobi in June 2026.

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